NAROTTAM MISHRA

GUARDIAN OF OFFENDED SENSIBILITIES

By Rahul Noronha



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He may be the home minister of Madhya Pradesh, but that does not stop 61-year-old Narottam Mishra from taking up issues that could hurt 'Hindu sensibilities' anywhere in the country. With a standing of 30 years in state politics, Mishra has succeeded in compelling 'offenders' to back down, earning a cult following in the bargain. He is placing himself as a principal challenger to Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, and many see his zeal as nothing more than an attempt to reinvent himself politically.

Amazon is only the latest target of the minister's ire. On January 25, Mishra directed the Madhya Pradesh director general of police to file an FIR against the e-commerce giant for allegedly selling a shoe with the Indian flag on it. "It has come to my attention that Amazon online platform had been using the national flag to sell its products.... Prima facie it seems to be a matter of violation of the flag code, which is hurtful. Insulting the country will not be tolerated at any cost," he tweeted. This is not even the first time that Mishra has acted against Amazon. In November 2021, a case was registered in Bhind against Amazon officials after it was found that marijuana was being sold on the online platform under the guise of selling stevia.

A little while ago, Mishra had threatened actress Sunny Leone with legal consequences over her latest video appearance for the song, *Madhuban Mein Radhika Nache*. "I am warning Sharib and Toshi (the singers) and Sunny Leone," he said on December 26 in Bhopal. "I am consulting legal experts and if they don't apologise and remove the song in three days, they will face legal consequences." Unwilling to feed the controversy, the producers agreed to change the song's title and lyrics, handing Mishra another victory in his cultural policing endeavours. Last October, it was a Dabur advertisement featuring a lesbian couple that got Mishra riled. Around the same time, members of a right-wing Hindu group vandalised the sets of Prakash Jha's *Aashram 3*, the popular web series that was being shot in Bhopal. The home minister termed the attack unfortunate but also called the rioters "patriotic". Mishra also promised to set up a body under the district collector to vet film scripts before giving them permission to shoot in the state. A few days later, fashion designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee found himself in the crosshairs after the minister deemed a *mangalsutra* ad obscene. Sabyasachi reacted like the others, quietly withdrawing the ad rather than courting controversy.

Political observers in the state attribute Mishra's newfound tendency to air an opinion on everything to his desire to stay in the news and to use the "Yogi [Adityanath] template" of taking a controversial, hardline stand to earn political dividends. While Chouhan's previous cabinets had hardliners, Mishra was not one of them. "Narottam Mishra is trying to carve out a separate political space for himself, distinct from CM Chouhan," says veteran journalist N.K. Singh. "He is no hardliner, but through his reactions on religious